

TWO WEEKS OUT

Fifteen Things Every Service Founder Has to Get Right

For consultancies, agencies, practices and firms.
Pulled from the fifty-six worksheets of The Owner's
Operating System.

George Cohlma

THE OWNER'S OPERATING SYSTEM

BEFORE YOU START

The problem isn't what you don't know. It's what you assume.

This is for people who sell their expertise. Consultancies, agencies, clinics, practices, studios, firms. Businesses where the thing being sold is work that people do.

Service businesses fail differently. Your capacity is hours, and hours don't scale by adding a warehouse. Your costs arrive weekly and your money arrives on somebody else's terms. And the person who sells the work is usually the person who delivers it.

If you came out of a job there's a second problem underneath that. You learned your habits on a platform you never had to think about. Payroll cleared. Someone watched the bank account. Someone handed you a target before the year started. Those habits came with you, and several of them quietly work against you.

Each of the fifteen says what it is, what ignoring it costs you, what it looks like in a real firm, and what to do about it this week. They're taken from the fifty-six worksheets that make up The Owner's Operating System.

Read it in an hour. Do one of them this week.

CONTENTS

Mindset

PART ONE

- 01 You're running on defaults you can't see.
- 02 Feeling better isn't the same as fixing it.
- 03 Nobody is coming to check.

Offer

PART TWO

- 04 Every bespoke job is a prototype you forgot to charge for.
- 05 Test the new service before you build the ability to deliver it.
- 06 Your hours are your inventory. Count them or you're guessing at everything.

Reach

PART THREE

- 07 Positioning is what you leave out.
- 08 Earn attention before you rent it.
- 09 One channel. Say out loud which one you're not doing.

Scale

PART FOUR

- 10 There are two kinds of sale. Know which one you're running.
- 11 If a new person couldn't run it in week two, it isn't a process.
- 12 A hire costs the full salary times the honest months.

Finances

PART FIVE

- 13 Profit and cash answer different questions.
- 14 Price too high and somebody tells you. Price too low and nobody does.
- 15 Decide the money moves while you're calm.

PART ONE

Mindset

The habits you brought with you, and the scaffolding nobody replaced.

01 You're running on defaults you can't see.

02 Feeling better isn't the same as fixing it.

03 Nobody is coming to check.

01

MINDSET

You're running on defaults you can't see.

You spent years inside a company that worked. Someone ran payroll. Someone watched the bank account. Someone handed you a budget in December that covered the whole next year. None of it was a decision you made, which is why none of it feels like one now.

The annual plan is the most expensive habit in the set. A large company can plan twelve months out because a hundred clients average each other out. You have six, and one of them changing scope moves your whole year.

WHY IT MATTERS

Plan for twelve months and you'll either keep spending against a plan that's already wrong, or feel like you're failing every month the real numbers don't match it. Both cost you money, and neither feels like a mistake while it's happening.

FOR EXAMPLE

A consultancy sets a twelve-month revenue plan in January. By March two of its four clients have changed scope. The owner keeps hiring and spending against the January numbers until June.

THE MOVE

Replace the annual plan with a rolling ninety days, reviewed on the first Monday of each month. Ninety days is far enough out to act on and close enough in to still be true.

02 MINDSET

Feeling better isn't the same as fixing it.

When something goes wrong with money, two problems arrive together. There's the money problem, and there's what the money problem is doing to your head. Only one of them has a business answer.

Cutting solves the other one, and it solves it immediately. You cancel everything cancellable and the fear lifts inside an hour, which is far too fast for anything to have actually been fixed.

WHY IT MATTERS

The relief is what does the damage, because it teaches you the move worked. Do it three quarters running and you've quietly dismantled the parts of the business that bring the next client in.

FOR EXAMPLE

A client gives notice in week one of the quarter. By Friday the owner has cancelled the marketing spend, a contractor and two subscriptions. Three of those were fine. The marketing was the only thing bringing replacements in, and the following quarter was worse than the one that scared him.

THE MOVE

Set one rule now, while nothing is wrong. No cut above a figure you choose today happens on the day you decide it. Twenty-four hours is enough for the relief to wear off and your judgement to come back.

03 MINDSET

Nobody is coming to check.

Corporate ran on forcing functions you didn't build and never noticed. A manager who asked. A quarterly review. A board pack with a date on it. None of that was your discipline. It was scaffolding, and you left it behind.

Now the only deadlines you have are the ones with a client attached. Everything else runs on whatever you install yourself, which most weeks is nothing at all.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is why you already know what you should be doing and still aren't doing it. The pricing review, the cash view, the standards you meant to write down. None of them has a person waiting, so all of them lose to a client email, every week, and it never once feels like a decision.

FOR EXAMPLE

An owner blocks Friday mornings for business development. A client asks for a call at ten. The block moves. Four weeks later the block is gone and nobody has mentioned it. The consequence lands two quarters later as an empty pipeline, and by then it looks like a market problem.

THE MOVE

Take the one thing you keep postponing and attach a person to it. A standing call, a peer who expects your number, an advisor who asks. Give it a face and a date, or it loses again next week.

PART TWO

Offer

What you repeat, what you're guessing at, and what an hour really costs you.

-
- 04 Every bespoke job is a prototype you forgot to charge for.
 - 05 Test the new service before you build the ability to deliver it.
 - 06 Your hours are your inventory. Count them or you're guessing at everything.
-

04 OFFER

Every bespoke job is a prototype you forgot to charge for.

The first time you build something for a client, you're inventing it. That's fine, and it's usually where the good work happens. The problem is the second time, and the third, when you invent it again from nothing because the first one was never written down as anything reusable.

Three clients, three approaches, no shared pieces. It feels like craftsmanship and it reads that way to clients, so nobody questions it.

WHY IT MATTERS

Invention is the most expensive hour in your business and you're giving it away at the same rate as the delivery. It's also the reason you can't hand work over, quote quickly, or take on the fourth client without adding a fourth person.

FOR EXAMPLE

A consultancy had run the same kind of operations review eleven times, every one starting from a blank document, and the twelfth took as long as the first. They spent two days writing down the questions they always ask and the shape of the report. The thirteenth took nine hours.

THE MOVE

Take the thing you've now delivered three or more times. Write down the steps, the template and the questions you always ask. Sell the next one as that, and price the custom work separately.

05

OFFER

Test the new service before you build the ability to deliver it.

The expensive part of a new service isn't the idea. It's the ability to deliver it. The hire, the training, the software, the certification. That's where the year goes, and it all gets spent before a single client has said yes.

You don't need any of it to find out whether anyone wants it. In a service business you can sell a thing long before you can deliver it well, then do the first few by hand, slowly and inefficiently, while you find out whether it's worth building properly.

WHY IT MATTERS

Build first and you find out after you're committed, when stopping means writing off a hire and saying so out loud. Sell first and a no costs you twelve conversations and a fortnight.

FOR EXAMPLE

A bookkeeping practice planned to add monthly advisory work. Before hiring anyone, they described it to twenty existing clients at a set monthly fee. Four signed. Enough to be worth running, not enough to hire for. So they ran those four by hand for a quarter, then hired on the back of it.

THE MOVE

Take the service you're considering. Before you spend anything on being able to deliver it, decide how many yeses would justify building it. Then describe it to twelve clients at a real price and count.

06

OFFER

Your hours are your inventory. Count them or you're guessing at everything.

In a service business the only thing you actually sell is hours. Not the deliverable, not the advice, not the outcome. Hours, dressed up as a project fee.

Which means you can't tell whether a client is profitable without counting them, and almost nobody counts. The prep is where it hides. The calls nobody booked, the revisions, the follow-up, the thinking you did on a Sunday.

WHY IT MATTERS

Without that number you don't know which clients make you money and which ones cost you. You'll price on instinct, take the wrong work, and grow revenue while going backwards.

FOR EXAMPLE

A design studio bills two clients twelve thousand each. One took sixty hours. The other took a hundred and ten. Same invoice, same apparent margin, and the second one earns barely half what the first does.

THE MOVE

Log every hour on your three largest clients for one month, prep separate from delivery. Divide each fee by its hours. Then take the worst one and decide: reprice it, rescope it, or let it go.

PART THREE

Reach

Being found. Who you're for, what earns attention, and the discipline of one channel.

-
- 07 Positioning is what you leave out.
 - 08 Earn attention before you rent it.
 - 09 One channel. Say out loud which one you're not doing.
-

07

REACH

Positioning is what you leave out.

A positioning sentence has two halves. Who you're for, and who you're not for. Most owners write the first and stop.

Service businesses resist the second half hardest, because turning work away feels reckless when the pipeline's thin. It's the opposite. A referral only happens when the person recommending you can describe what you do, in one sentence, to somebody who has never met you.

WHY IT MATTERS

Without the second half you get compared on price, because there's nothing else to compare you on. And you stay hard to pass along, so the cheapest source of clients you have never really works.

FOR EXAMPLE

A finance consultancy described itself as helping businesses grow. Referrals were rare and vague when they came. They changed it to fractional finance for construction firms between five and thirty million. Half their inquiries now arrive already knowing what they do.

THE MOVE

Write both halves, and make the second one specific enough that it excludes somebody you'd have quite liked to work with. Then use it on the next inquiry that isn't a fit, and refer them somewhere better.

08

REACH

Earn attention before you rent it.

When you need clients, the first instinct is to buy attention. Ads, sponsored posts, a bought list. It rarely works for a service business, because nobody hires a stranger to do work that matters to them.

What they hire is evidence. One piece of writing that only somebody who does this work could have produced. Not an overview of your field. The specific thing you've learned from doing it two hundred times, aimed at whatever your client is actually worried about.

WHY IT MATTERS

Advertising stops the day you stop paying for it, and it converts badly while your name still means nothing. A piece only you could have written keeps bringing people in for years, and it's what makes paid attention work later, once you do buy it.

FOR EXAMPLE

An employment lawyer writes up the three contract clauses that cause most of the claims she sees. Not employment law in general. Those three, and what goes wrong in each. It took an afternoon, and it's brought inquiries for two years.

THE MOVE

Take a question a client asked you last month that you could answer better than anyone else they'd have asked. Write the answer this month. Put one line at the end asking for an email address, and count replies rather than opens.

09 REACH

One channel. Say out loud which one you're not doing.

Right now you're probably doing four or five things at once. A bit of writing, some networking, an ad you keep meaning to turn off, a newsletter that goes out when you remember. None of them gets enough of you to work, and none of them feels safe to stop, because each one has worked for somebody.

The choice is much easier made backwards. Look at how your last ten clients actually arrived, not how you hoped they would. For most service businesses it turns out to be one person who recommended you rather than a channel you paid for.

WHY IT MATTERS

A channel needs about a quarter of steady effort before it tells you anything. Split across five, not one of them ever gets that, so you spend a year busy and learn nothing about any of them. Stopping four is what buys the fifth a fair test.

FOR EXAMPLE

A physiotherapy clinic's best patients all came through GP referrals. They were also running ads, a newsletter and social. They stopped all three for a quarter and spent that time visiting surgeries instead. Referrals went from six a month to nineteen.

THE MOVE

Write down how your last ten clients found you. Whichever route brought the most gets all of your effort this quarter. Then write down the two you're stopping, and the date you'll judge the one you kept.

PART FOUR

Scale

What holds together when you're not the one doing the work, and what a person actually costs.

10 There are two kinds of sale. Know which one you're running.

11 If a new person couldn't run it in week two, it isn't a process.

12 A hire costs the full salary times the honest months.

10

 SCALE

There are two kinds of sale. Know which one you're running.

You almost certainly sell both. A small entry piece somebody decides on in a week, and a large engagement that takes months and involves people you never meet. Most owners have never named either, so both get the same follow-up and the same proposal.

They need different things. The large one has to travel without you in the room, because the decision happens after you leave. The gaps between conversations are weeks, so contact has to be useful rather than chasing. And the buyer is risking their own judgement, so proof beats enthusiasm.

WHY IT MATTERS

Run the large sale the way you run the small one and you'll lose it slowly, without ever hearing why. It reads as a closing problem, so you push harder on the follow-up, which is the one thing guaranteed to make it worse.

FOR EXAMPLE

A studio kept losing its larger rebrand work after a strong first meeting. They started sending a short written summary the buyer could forward, with two comparable projects and what each cost. Nothing about the pitch changed. Three of the next five closed.

THE MOVE

Take your largest open opportunity. Write one page the buyer could forward to somebody who has never met you, with what you'd do, what it costs, and one comparable job. Send it this week.

11

SCALE

If a new person couldn't run it in week two, it isn't a process.

The first time somebody else delivers your work, clients start having a different experience. Not worse, exactly. Different. And you can't say precisely what changed, which is why you quietly take the work back.

What's missing is written down. Three or four things that have to be true every time you deliver, each answerable yes or no. If checking one needs your judgement, you've written an opinion, and the person checking will drift toward whatever they'd have done themselves.

WHY IT MATTERS

Anything that lives only in your head is a ceiling on the size of the firm. And the way you'll respond to the drift is to do the work yourself, which is what makes the ceiling permanent.

FOR EXAMPLE

Two consultants ran the same workshop. One sent a written summary within two days and the other didn't. The client who got nothing renewed at half the scope. Nobody had ever written down that the summary was part of the work, so nobody had done anything wrong.

THE MOVE

Take the thing you deliver most often and write the three or four things that have to be true every time. Then hand a finished piece of work to somebody who joined two weeks ago and ask them to tell you whether it met them.

12

SCALE

A hire costs the full salary times the honest months.

You hire when you're full. There's more work than hours, you're turning things away or delivering late, and another person looks like the obvious answer.

The number that decides it isn't the salary. It's the full cost, tax and benefits included, multiplied by the months before that person bills at full rate.

Owners always guess that second number low, because the hire gets made when the workload feels urgent, and urgency shortens every estimate.

WHY IT MATTERS

A hire made against the runway you're expecting rather than the one you have is how a good year ends badly. In a service business the ramp is longer than you think, because they have to learn your clients and your standards before anything they do is chargeable.

FOR EXAMPLE

An accountancy firm needs a senior at ninety thousand. Fully loaded that's a hundred and twelve. Honestly billing at full rate in month five. Forty-seven thousand of exposure against four months of cash. They took a contractor two days a week instead, and hired in the spring.

THE MOVE

Write four numbers before you write the job advert. Full cost, honest months to full billing, real runway, start date. If the exposure is bigger than the runway, the answer is a contractor, a part-time start, or a price rise. It isn't a cheaper hire.

PART FIVE

Finances

The money underneath all of it. Timing, price, and the decisions you make while you're calm.

13 Profit and cash answer different questions.

14 Price too high and somebody tells you. Price too low and nobody does.

15 Decide the money moves while you're calm.

13

FINANCES

Profit and cash answer different questions.

You invoice when the work's done and get paid thirty or sixty days later. Salaries go out every month regardless. So a profitable month can still contain a week where you can't cover payroll, and a monthly average hides that week completely.

Growth makes it sharper rather than safer. Winning work means paying people to deliver it months before anybody pays you for it, so the better the quarter, the wider the gap gets.

WHY IT MATTERS

Service businesses fail on the way up, and it looks nothing like underperformance until the week it arrives. By then every option in front of you is an expensive one.

FOR EXAMPLE

An agency won two new clients in the same month and hired to deliver them. Salaries started immediately. The first invoices went out ninety days later. The best quarter they'd ever had was also the one where they nearly missed payroll.

THE MOVE

Build a thirteen-week cash view and update it every Monday in fifteen minutes. Set a minimum cash number, not zero, below which you change what you're doing.

14

FINANCES

Price too high and somebody tells you. Price too low and nobody does.

If your rate's too high you find out. People hesitate, push back, walk away, and you adjust. If it's too low, nothing happens at all. They sign, the work starts, and the number is now the number.

In a service business that's worse than elsewhere, because your price is attached to a relationship. Raising it means going back to people who are perfectly happy and telling them something they didn't ask to hear.

WHY IT MATTERS

So it compounds quietly. Every new client anchors to the old number, and the gap between what you charge and what the work is worth widens for as long as you leave it. Undercharge by twenty per cent for four years and you've funded somebody else's business out of your own.

FOR EXAMPLE

A freelancer set seventy-five an hour in year one because it felt safe. Four years on she told every client the rate would be ninety-five from January. One left. The rest stayed, and that year earned more than the two before it combined.

THE MOVE

Write your current rate next to what the work is worth to the client, using their numbers rather than yours. Then set the date the new rate starts, and tell every client before it does rather than after.

15

FINANCES

Decide the money moves while you're calm.

Most owners don't plan their funding. They react. And when you react, the only money on offer is the expensive kind. High interest credit, factoring at a bad rate, an investor who knows exactly how badly you need them.

The cheap money has to be arranged before you need it. A deposit taken up front. A retainer instead of a project fee. A credit line opened in a quarter when the account looks healthy.

WHY IT MATTERS

The day you need money is the day you've got the least leverage to ask for it. Everything is priced on how it looks from the outside, and a quiet quarter and a bad one look nothing alike to a lender.

FOR EXAMPLE

A staffing firm's largest client stretched payment from thirty days to sixty. Payroll was due on Friday either way. They drew on a credit line opened eighteen months earlier, in a quarter when they didn't need it, at a rate nobody would have offered them that week.

THE MOVE

Open the credit line this quarter, while you don't need it. Put the capital plan on one page in plain words, and show it to one person who will ask you about it again.

BEFORE YOU CLOSE THIS

Fifteen questions you should be able to answer.

Tick the ones you could answer right now with a real figure or a real name, not a rough sense. What you leave blank is the work, and the number points you at the item it came from.

- ☐ 01 How far ahead does your plan run, and when did you last change it?
- ☐ 02 What's the largest cut you'd make today without sleeping on it first?
- ☐ 03 What have you postponed three weeks running, and who is waiting on it?
- ☐ 04 What have you delivered three times or more, and is any of it written down?
- ☐ 05 How many clients would have to say yes before you'd build your next service?
- ☐ 06 Which of your clients earns you the least per hour?
- ☐ 07 Who do you turn away?
- ☐ 08 What have you published that only somebody doing your work could have written?
- ☐ 09 Which channel brought your last ten clients?
- ☐ 10 What have you sent your largest open deal that the buyer could forward?
- ☐ 11 What are the three or four things that have to be true every time you deliver?
- ☐ 12 How many months until your next hire bills at full rate?
- ☐ 13 What's your minimum cash number?
- ☐ 14 When did you last raise your rate, and what triggers the next one?
- ☐ 15 What does your credit line cost, and is it open?

TWO WEEKS OUT

Where this came from

These fifteen are taken from the fifty-six worksheets inside The Owner's Operating System, a program for people moving from a job into a business they own. Each item names the worksheets it came from.

The worksheets go further than a booklet can. They ask for your numbers, your rate, your runway, your names. They produce a document you keep. This is the argument. Those are the instruments.

If one of these landed hard enough that you want to work it properly, that's the one to start with.

twoweeksout.com

The Owner's Operating System · ten modules · fifty-six worksheets

© 2026 Two Weeks Out. Copyright and confidential. Prepared for the named recipient. Not for distribution.